

PORTRAIT OF JUBILATION
The top leadership with Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the party headquarters in the national capital, Mar. 10

THE OUTCOME OF THE ELECTION HAS SILENCED CRITICS WHO SAID BRAND MODI WAS ON THE WANE, ESPECIALLY AFTER THE BENGAL ROUT

lieved Brand Modi was on the decline, especially after the party's rout in the West Bengal assembly election last year. There is little doubt that the prime minister's towering presence, in addition to the formidable election machinery that Union home minister Amit Shah has put in place for the party, remained key factors in its current wins. However, the UP election has also brought Yogi into the spotlight, with the party allowing him unusual leeway during the campaign and even using the descriptor 'Yogi Sarkar' rather than invoking the BJP brand. Yogi was the prime campaigner in the state, undertaking as many as 300-odd solo rallies across the state, with both Modi and Shah joining in tactical spurts. Madhav says as much, "It is the Modi-Yogi combination that worked well in UP."

Yogi's elevation as chief minister in 2017, bypassing a whole range of contenders, is now clearly emerging as part of a larger BJP-RSS game plan to ensure a rapid expansion of the Hindu vote bank. Before he became chief minister, Yogi, a five-time MP, represented the extreme face of Hindutva and often criticised his counterparts in the Sangh Parivar—he is himself not of RSS stock—for pursuing a softer version of the Hindutva ideology. He was given the top post by Shah and Modi, in consultation with the RSS, because, as a monk, he could have a pan-caste appeal. Some of that came under strain with a perception of 'Thakurvaad'—Yogi is a Rajput originally from Garhwal—but eventually, he held up his end, running the rainbow coalition of castes that the BJP had put together and following the party high command diktats when it came to governing the state. These results now put Yogi squarely on the national stage and, some say, among the frontline contenders to succeed Modi.

That said, Modi remains head and shoulders above the rest of the phalanx of BJP leaders. As one of them puts it, "Modi occupies the No. 1 to 10 positions in terms of leadership. Any contender has to start at No. 11." Till recently, Amit Shah was seen as the logical successor to Modi. A relationship going back to their Gujarat days, Shah has been Modi's right-hand man, and someone whose organisational skills remain unmatched. Soon after his induction as home minister in 2019, Shah emerged as the hardline face of Hindutva, leading the coup to repeal Article 370, and bringing in the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) that disallowed Muslim refugees in India from applying for citizenship. Just as L.K. Advani was seen as the Hindu hardliner when A.B. Vajpayee was PM, Shah assumed that mantle in Modi's second term. Everyone agrees Shah remains and will continue to be a redoubtable force in the party, in addition to being the prime contender to succeed Modi.

Electoral strategists, however, do discern a gradual shift, with Yogi now emerging as one of Hindutva's key mascots whom the parivar will use to help consolidate and expand the Hindu vote bank across the country. Talking about the emergence of "a political Hindu", RSS and BJP ideologue Seshadri R. Chari says, "While, at a philosophical level, the RSS may push for an assertive Hindutva, at the practical level, it needs a political leader who can push for it aggressively. Yogi is emerging as that face. The new formula could be that Modi represents the softer face of Hindutva and pushes the development agenda,